Reading & Writing Warm-Up Drills

Quick, focused drills to sharpen one skill at a time before a full-length test. Each item names the TEKS it practices. Answers are at the end.

Vocabulary (2B, 2C)

1. In "The storm was *relentless*, never stopping for days," *relentless* means — A. gentle B. unending C. short D. quiet
2. The root *path* (feeling) shows that *sympathy* means — A. a feeling with or for another B. a path C. a star D. a leader
3. The root *duc* means *lead*, so *conduct* most likely means — A. to follow B. to lead or guide C. to stop D. to break

Comprehension & Inference (5F, 5G)

4. A character "grabbed an umbrella and sighed at the gray sky." You can infer that — A. it is sunny B. it may rain C. she is joyful D. it is midnight
5. The sentence that states what a paragraph is mostly about is the — A. minor detail B. central idea C. quotation D. title

Author's Craft (9A, 9D, 9G)

6. "The wind *whispered* through the trees" is an example of — A. simile B. personification C. hyperbole D. irony
7. "As busy as a bee" is a — A. metaphor B. simile C. fact D. fallacy
8. An author who writes to convince you to recycle has the purpose to — A. entertain B. inform C. persuade D. confuse
9. "Everybody owns this phone, so you should too" is which fallacy? — A. bandwagon B. circular reasoning C. analogy D. irony

Literary Elements (7B, 7C)

10. A scene that jumps back to a character's childhood is a — A. flashback B. climax C. setting D. theme
11. An early hint about a later event is — A. irony B. foreshadowing C. mood D. plot

Revising & Editing (10B, 10C, 10D)

12. Which transition shows contrast? — A. In addition B. However C. For example D. First
13. The best sentence to add a detail is one that — A. repeats the topic B. gives a specific fact or example C. changes the subject D. asks a question
14. "The team of players *are* ready." Best change — A. *are → is* B. *team → teams* C. *players → player* D. no change
15. "*Its* going to rain." Best change — A. *Its → It's* B. *going → gone* C. *rain → Rain* D. no change

16. "*Me and him* went." Best change — A. *Me and him → He and I* B. *went → gone* C. no change D. add a comma

17. "*There* going to *their* house." The first word should be — A. *They're* B. *Their* C. no change D. deleted

18. "We *seen* the movie." Best change — A. *seen → saw* B. *movie → movies* C. no change D. *We → Us*

Answer Key

1. B — 2B · 2. A — 2C · 3. B — 2C · 4. B — 5F · 5. B — 5G · 6. B — 9D · 7. B — 9D · 8. C — 9A · 9. A — 9G · 10. A — 7C · 11. B — 7C · 12. B — 10B·i · 13. B — 10C · 14. A — 10D·i · 15. A — 10D·vii · 16. A — 10D · 17. A — 10D·vii · 18. A — 10D·ii

Glossary of Literary & Craft Terms

The terms the STAAR Grade 8 Reading standards expect you to know. Questions often use these exact words.

Story elements

Theme — the message or lesson, shown through characters and events. *(7A)*

Character motivation — why a character acts as they do. *(7B)*

Flashback — a scene that jumps back to an earlier time. *(7C)*

Foreshadowing — an early hint about what will happen. *(7C)*

Subplot — a smaller story beside the main plot. *(7C)*

Setting — when and where a story takes place. *(7D)*

Figurative language & devices

Simile — a comparison using *like/as*. *(9D)*

Metaphor — a comparison without *like/as*. *(9D)*

Extended metaphor — a metaphor developed over several lines. *(9D)*

Personification — human traits given to non-human things. *(9D)*

Irony — a contrast between expectation and reality. *(9E)*

Point of view — who tells the story. *(9E)*

Mood — the feeling a text creates. *(9F)*

Tone — the author's attitude. *(9F)*

Voice — the author's distinct personality. *(9F)*

Rhetoric & argument

Analogy — explaining one thing using another. *(9G)*

Juxtaposition — placing two things side by side for contrast. *(9G)*

Bandwagon appeal — "everyone's doing it." *(9G)*

Circular reasoning — using a claim to prove itself. *(9G)*

Claim — the position an argument defends. *(8E)*

Counter-argument — the opposing side, answered. *(8E)*

Audience — the readers a text is written for. *(8E)*

Thesis / controlling idea — the main point. *(8D, 10B)*

Genres

Poetry — lines and stanzas; watch line length and punctuation. *(8B)*

Drama — a play in acts and scenes with stage directions. *(8C)*

Informational / argumentative / persuasive — explains / defends a claim / convinces.

Correspondence — letters and emails. *(11D)*

Grammar & Conventions Quick Reference

Everything the Grade 8 editing questions check, on one page. (Standard 10D.)

Sentences (10D·i)

- **Complete sentence:** a subject + a verb + a complete thought.
- **Fragment:** "Running to the bus." → "She was running to the bus."
- **Run-on / comma splice:** "I was tired, I slept." → "I was tired, so I slept."

Subject-Verb Agreement (10D·i)

The verb matches the **subject**, not a word in between: "The **box** of markers **is** here" (ignore *of markers*). Singular → *is, has, runs*; plural → *are, have, run*.

Verb Tense & Voice (10D·ii)

Keep tense **consistent**. Use correct forms: *saw* (not "seen"), *gone* (not "went" after *have*).

Pronouns (10D·iii, iv)

Case: *I, he, she, we, they* as subjects; *me, him, her, us, them* as objects ("He and **I** went"; "between you and **me**").
Agreement: a pronoun matches its noun in number.

Capitalization & Punctuation (10D·v, vi)

- Capitalize sentence starts, proper nouns, and *I*.
- **Comma** around a nonrestrictive phrase: "My dog, a beagle, barks."
- **Semicolon** joins related sentences: "It rained; we stayed in."
- **Colon** introduces a list: "Bring three things: a pen, paper, and a book."
- **Parentheses** add extra info: "The test (held in April) was long."

Commonly Confused Words (10D·vii)

Word	Means	Example
its / it's	belonging to it / it is	The dog wagged its tail. It's raining.
there / their / they're	a place / belonging to them / they are	There it is. Their house. They're here.

to / two / too	toward / 2 / also	Go to class. Two pens. Me too.
affect / effect	to change / a result	Rain affects plants. The effect was clear.
your / you're	belonging to you / you are	Your book. You're right.
our / are	belonging to us / verb	Our class. We are ready.
whole / hole	entire / an opening	The whole day. A hole in the sock.
a lot	many (two words)	A lot of people came.

Greek & Latin Roots, Prefixes & Suffixes

Word parts help you unlock unfamiliar words. (Supports vocabulary standard 2C.)

Roots named in the Grade 8 standard	
ast	star — astronomy
qui	quiet, rest — tranquil
path	feeling — sympathy
mand / mend	order — command
duc	lead — conduct

More common roots	
port	carry — transport
spect	look — inspect
dict	say — predict
scrib/script	write — manuscript
tele	far — telescope
bio	life — biology
graph	write — paragraph
geo	earth — geography
aud	hear — audible
vis / vid	see — visible

Common prefixes	
re-	again, back — return
un- / in-	not — unfair, incorrect
pre-	before — preview
mis-	wrongly — mistake
dis-	opposite — disagree
inter-	between — interact
sub-	under — submarine

Common suffixes	
-able / -ible	able to be — readable
-tion / -sion	the act of — action
-ology	the study of — biology
-ist	one who — scientist
-ful	full of — helpful
-less	without — hopeless

Strategy: Break a hard word into parts. *Transport* = *trans* (across) + *port* (carry) → to carry across. Combine word-part clues with the **context** of the sentence (2B) for your best meaning.